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To cite this article: Andrea Beccaro (2022) ISIS in Libya and beyond, 2014–2016, The Journal of North African Studies, 27:1, 160-179, DOI: [10.1080/13629387.2020.1747445](https://doi.org/10.1080/13629387.2020.1747445)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/13629387.2020.1747445>



Published online: 29 Mar 2020.



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ISIS in Libya and beyond, 2014–2016

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ABSTRACT

ISIS (the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria) has been a key political and military actor in the Middle East and in North Africa. Although it is currently in retreat, it has conquered, controlled, and ruled areas of Syria, Iraq, and Libya. This essay outlines threats posed by ISIS in Libya and in North Africa. The analysis is divided into three sections. The first section takes into account the hybrid military nature of ISIS. The notion of hybrid warfare describes the way in which non-state actors fight: a mix of traditional infantry tactics using modern weapons; guerrilla operations; and terrorism. The second section focuses on Libya. Over the summer of 2014, Libya collapsed into civil war between duelling governments. This turmoil offered ISIS an opening to set up a bridgehead along the Libyan coast. The role of ISIS is analysed in the context of Libyan political and security chaos, underlining both ISIS's role in the conflict and ISIS's operations in Sirte. The third section takes into account ISIS's operations in the North Africa between 2015 and 2016. The group has proved to be resilient; although the loss of its North African capital was a strategic blow, this has not removed ISIS's ability to execute small-unit raids, and bombings. In conclusion, the paper aims to demonstrate both the hybrid nature of ISIS, which affects various military and political approaches and allows ISIS to withstand classic counterterrorism operations. It also considers ISIS's ability to operate across borders and to exploit local instability.

KEYWORDS Islamic state; Libya; North Africa; hybrid warfare; terrorism

This paper has been presented at “CAPOLCOT II. International Conference Political Change and Territorial Conflicts in North Africa and Middle East”, University of Granada, Spain, 24 November 2018.

Although ISIS (the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria) has been almost completely militarily defeated, it has been a key political and military actor in the Middle East and in North Africa, and it has conquered and controlled areas in Syria, Iraq, and Libya. Moreover, it has a foothold in the Sinai Peninsula, has carried out terrorist attacks in several countries, and, along with other militias, such as Al-Qaeda in the Islamic Maghreb (AQIM), Uqbah Ibn Nafi, and Ansar al-Sharia, it represents one of the main threats for the North Africa region's stability.

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After the collapse of the Muammar Gaddafi regime, several militias with different ideologies and interests related to arms and human smuggling/trafficking, along with other criminal activities, began to proliferate in Libya. Therefore, the Libyan security landscape became very complex. It included quasi-regular armies such as the Misrata militias, which support the internationally recognised government of al-Sarraj based in Tripoli, the Libyan National Army led by General Khalifa Haftar based in Tobruk, and several other militias such as ISIS. This paper focuses on the latter, its nature, and its role in Libya and in North Africa.

Consequently, the paper's analysis adopts a multidisciplinary approach and is divided into three different sections. The first takes into account both the nature of African conflicts and the hybrid nature of ISIS, establishing the framework for a more detailed discussion on ISIS operations. ISIS's hybrid fighting strategy enables ISIS both to operate across state borders and to be resilient and also quite adaptable. In order to give a precise idea of the nature of ISIS and of the character of this kind of threat, the paper delves into the Strategic/Security studies literature on Africa conflicts, irregular warfare, and mainly the notion of hybrid warfare provided by Frank Hoffman. The second section studies Libya itself. Over the summer of 2014, Libya collapsed into civil war between two governments. This turmoil offered ISIS an opening to set up a bridgehead along the Libyan coast. The role of ISIS is analysed in the framework of Libyan security chaos, mainly taking into account its operations in Sirte. In this section the paper focuses less on theory and more on what happened in Libya. For this reason, it takes into account different points of views such as local political situations, different socio-religious environments, and particular events. At the same time, it uses different levels of analysis, from political/strategic to tactical ones, in order to describe Libya's security situation, ISIS operations, and the combat in Sirte. The third section considers ISIS's regional links and actions, showing different military capabilities based on different tactics and weaponry. It takes into account three countries, Algeria, Tunisia, and Egypt, in order to show at a regional level and from a security perspective how ISIS has been able to operate in the region.

Combining different methodologies and levels of analysis the paper intends to both offer a detailed image of ISIS in Libya and in North Africa from a theoretical and practical point of view; and to look at the same security issue from different perspectives and angles to give a more complete idea of the phenomenon. Moreover, confronting the theoretical debate on hybrid warfare and ISIS operations in Libya, the paper aims to evaluate the effectiveness of hybrid warfare.

As a result, the paper deals with at least three main features of ISIS. First, there is ISIS's willingness – and, on some occasions, as in Sirte, its ability – to conquer terrain and to defend it. This strategic goal is also demonstrated

by the attempt to conquer Derna in Libya and Ben Gardane in Tunisia, and by its control of part of Sinai. In terms of security, this has two consequences. On the one hand, it means that counter-insurgency operations are more likely to be useful against ISIS and future similar groups. On the other hand, control of terrain is crucial in order to eradicate this kind of threat. Second, cross-border operations are likely to be an important element of ISIS's operations. Third, ISIS has demonstrated a remarkable ability to deploy different tactics, giving credit to the idea of a hybrid militia. ISIS used classic terrorist operations in Libya, Tunisia, Algeria, and Egypt when it did not have control of terrain or sought to strike outside the main theatre of operations. At the same time, it has been able to coordinate more traditional infantry deployment, like the operations to conquer Sirte or to attack Ben Gardane, and to use advanced weapons in Sinai.

ISIS as hybrid militia

The section below delves into the Strategic/Security Studies debate on Africa conflicts and hybrid warfare in order to give a precise idea of the nature and character of ISIS and similar groups. Before proceeding to examine ISIS's operations in Libya, it is important to take into account the strategic situation in Africa in order to have a better idea of African security as a whole. According to the Africa Center for Strategic Studies 'militant Islamist group activity in Africa has doubled since 2012 when there were 1,402 events linked to these groups. Over the past 10 years, there has been a ten-fold increase in violent events (from 288 in 2009–3,050 in 2018)' (Africa Center for Strategic Studies 2019).

Paul Williams (2017) distinguishes between two kinds of conflict in Africa: one is rooted in the African state system (Allen 1999) and fought principally over access to state power; the other, which is more important for this paper, occurs on the margins or outside the society of states. According to Isabelle Duyvesteyn (2005), the African conflict experience is marked by civil or internal wars, and most of them have a tendency to spill over into neighbouring states. They are fought for reasons other than acquiring state power by a range of non-state actors including warlord factions, clans, tribes, and various types of militia (Hills 1997; Rich 1999). ISIS is a perfect example of this second type of African conflict and it has taken advantage of instability, insecurity, and political vacuums to expand, establish new links, and extend its influence.

Therefore, ISIS can exploit two different but interlinked phenomena. First of all, 'these conflicts are rarely confined to the territory of just one state and they are all influenced, to a greater or lesser degree, by dynamics and processes at the local, national, regional, and global levels' (Williams 2017). Second, since 2010, Islamist groups have become more prominent actors in Africa's conflict landscape. Their increasing relevance is also demonstrated by the

ever more frequent use of 'remote violence' such as IEDs (Improvised Explosive Devices) and suicide attacks. Especially significant is the rapidly rising use of suicide bombings: according to a database compiled by the University of Chicago, 465 of the 483 suicide attacks in Africa occurred between 2007 and 2016.

Another common feature of Africa's wars is that they are often waged by tribally based militias, and consequently ethnic/tribal interests are crucial in ensuring access to valuable resources and in cementing or breaking off alliances (Le Sage 2010; Clapham 1998). A further problem of African conflicts is that, as in Kaldor's 'new wars' theory (Kaldor 1999; Ellis 2003), winning is not essential because local actors benefit from the crisis. Moreover, African conflicts have a strong relationship with organised crime, human trafficking, and smuggling of different products from drugs to cigarettes and weapons. According to Le Sage, Africa 'has emerged as a major transit hub for narcotics from South America and South Asia to reach Europe' (Le Sage 2010).

ISIS is a latecomer in this landscape, but it has been able to settle in, not only conquering terrain, such as Sirte in Libya, but also forming part of a flourishing criminal economy that fuels African conflicts. As a result, the notion of 'terrorist group' as used to describe ISIS is too narrow. Although ISIS has carried out attacks such as car bombings and suicide attacks, which can be labelled as terrorism, instead it is a militia that can be more precisely defined using the term 'hybrid warfare'.

The term 'hybrid warfare' was introduced by Frank Hoffman, who states that it 'incorporate[s] a full range of different modes of warfare including conventional capabilities, irregular tactics and formations, terrorist acts including indiscriminate violence and coercion, and criminal disorder. [...] These multi-modal activities can be conducted by separate units, or even by the same unit, but are generally operationally and tactically directed and coordinated within the main battle space to achieve synergistic effects in the physical and psychological dimensions of conflict' (Hoffman 2007, 8).

As a consequence, hybrid warfare represents a mix of different tactics and uses different kinds of weapons. For instance, ISIS has extensively used terrorism but it has also used guerrilla warfare, hit and runs operations and even more conventional operations in Syria and Iraq against both Kurds and Iraqi Security Forces. In Libya this more conventional approach has not been adopted probably because ISIS never became the strongest Libyan militia. As far as weapons are concerned, ISIS has used not only small arms but also missiles, propaganda and media coverage in order to weaken the enemy. The dozens of videos published in the past years are example of its propaganda campaign.

The hybrid warfare concept is based on four key elements that describe ISIS's warfare (Beccaro 2018a). First, in hybrid wars, regular and irregular units become blurred into the same force in the same battle space. While

they are operationally integrated and tactically fused, the irregular component of the force attempts to become operationally decisive rather than just protract the conflict (Hoffman 2007, 8).

In Iraq and Syria, ISIS used conventional infantry tactics on several occasions. For instance, in northern Iraq it used artillery fire to attack Kurds' Peshmerga, and in al-Anbar, it manoeuvred units transported in several vehicles around the battlefield in order to achieve the element of surprise. Moreover, during the battle of Ramadi in the spring of 2015, ISIS used very effective tactics, combining suicide attacks to break the defensive lines of Iraqi Security Forces and then infantry assaults (Knights and Mello 2015). ISIS also commandeered tanks and other military equipment seized from the Iraqi Army. This represented a major difference between ISIS's operations in Iraq and those in Libya, because there it has never had the same kind of arsenal it had in Iraq, because in Libya, it was a latecomer militia and was not able to capture a considerable amount of military equipment.

The second element of hybrid warfare is that terrorism becomes the main fighting method, because terrorist tactics are easier and cheaper to use than more conventional ones and can be used far from the main theatre of operation. However, ISIS is not a 'pure' terrorist group for at least two reasons. First, 'pure' terrorist groups do not hold terrain as ISIS did in Iraq and Syria and governed several cities: Raqqa, Mosul, Ramadi, Tikrit, and Falluja. Its foothold in Libya has been more limited, yet it conquered and ruled for several months the city of Sirte. According to Cronin, 'If ISIS is purely and simply anything, it is a pseudo-state led by a conventional army' (Cronin 2015). As a consequence, and this is the second reason, ISIS could be better defined as an insurgent group because insurgency includes both guerrilla tactics and terrorism. From a historical point of view, insurgent groups' tactics have always ranged from almost conventional operations to guerrilla-style warfare to terrorism. The choice between these differing tactics is often made based on the local military situation and on the strength of the group. This explains, for instance, why ISIS cannot be considered defeated in Libya just because it lost Sirte. It could use different fighting methods in order to achieve its goals. It could use 'hit and run' operations instead of a static defence like that of urban areas. Moreover, the role of terrorism in ISIS's warfare is fundamental to its ideology and its transnational nature. According to Lia, '[un]like ethno-nationalist revolts or revolutionary struggles against national authorities, jihadists are not ideologically bound to fight in only one country or against one specific national regime' (Lia 2016). Terrorism is an effective tactic to cross national borders and strike targets that are not in the main theatre of operations.

The third elements of hybrid groups is their use of modern technology 'to avoid predictability and seek advantage in unexpected ways and ruthless modes of attack' (Hoffman 2007, 16). ISIS has been able to use modern

technology in order to deploy new kinds of weaponry and devise different methods of attack, mainly suicide operations. ISIS has applied technology in several different ways. First, it has broadcast its propaganda through social media and the Internet. Second, it has used or modified modern weapons. The use of drones by ISIS (Bunker 2015), as well as poison gas were used mainly in Syria and Iraq (Strack 2017); it has also manufactured its own sniper rifles and sub-machine guns, which it has used in Libya (Bunker and Keshavarz 2016). Third, the extensive use of suicide attacks could be explained by looking at its tactical benefit. In fact, ISIS has often used terrorism to soften enemy defences for its infantry to exploit (Beccaro and Bertolotti 2015).

The fourth element of hybrid warfare is related to the battlefield. A hybrid war, like every irregular war, takes place in complex terrain, most likely the burgeoning cities of the developing world. As a result, today's conflicts are fought more often in urban areas. Whereas the 'urbanization of conflicts' is a global trend rooted in 'rapid population growth, accelerating urbanization, littoralization (the tendency for things to cluster on coastlines), and increasing connectedness' (Kilkullen 2013, 25), the Mediterranean region is particularly affected. There the urban population 'grew by 40 million between 1970 and 2000, and three-quarters of that growth was in North Africa and the Middle East' (Kilkullen 2013, 32). This element has been important for ISIS in Iraq, especially its operations in Mosul, Falluja, and Ramadi. However, it could be less relevant in Libya due to its vast desert areas. On the other hand, ISIS can use this uncontrolled space to move and disperse. Nevertheless, it should be remembered that ISIS took over Sirte and first operated in Derna.

In summary, ISIS might be better defined as a hybrid militia than a 'pure' terrorist group. This is a key point in understanding the kind of threat posed by such a group in Libya and in North Africa. The following part of this paper moves on to describe in greater detail concerning the role of ISIS in the context of the collapse of Libya after the summer of 2014.

ISIS in Libya: from summer of 2014 to the fall of Sirte, December 2016

So far, this paper has focused on ISIS, its nature, and its military capabilities. The following part of the paper will discuss the Libyan political and security situation in the aftermath of the fall of the Gaddafi regime, with two goals in mind. The first is to understand why the Libyan vacuum helped ISIS to establish a foothold. The second is to analyse ISIS's operations in Libya from 2014 in order to illustrate both its hybrid nature and its military capabilities. This part of the paper is divided into three main sections. The first, after having briefly summarised important features of Libyan history, focuses on the general situation in Libya at a political level in the aftermath of the fall of the Gaddafi regime. The second section delves deeper into how ISIS was

able to exploit Libya's volatile situation. The third section describes the military operations in Sirte, the largest Libyan city that ISIS was able to conquer and defend for several months.

In order to understand Libyan instability, it is important to briefly summarise its history. Until the Italian occupation in 1911, Libya had been divided into three different regions: Cyrenaica, Tripolitania, and Fezzan. These three regions had, and still have, different economies and commercial and political links to the wider region. In 1951, Libya became an independent state and adopted a federal constitution (a constitutional monarchy) that gave significant power to the three regions. In 1969, Gaddafi seized power and neglected Cyrenaica, although it is home to about two thirds of Libyan oil reserves. Moreover, during Gaddafi's time the bulk of oil revenue from Cyrenaica ended up in Tripolitania and in Sirte, Gaddafi's hometown.

Since the fall of Gaddafi, several militias, governments, and tribal leaders have tried to govern the country, with little success (Daraghi 2015). For instance, on 6 March 2012 a group of tribal leaders established the Cyrenaica Transitional Council (CTC), then renamed the Council of Cyrenaica in Libya (CCL). Key CCL demands included the transformation of Libya into a federal state with a regional parliament. Such a solution was, however, opposed by some groups because it would have given Cyrenaica control of oil revenues (Pusztai 2016).

As far as the security situation, two problems have to be taken into account. The first related to the armed forces and the police. During Gaddafi's regime 'the troops were organized primarily with a view to protecting the regime from a *coup d'état*'. Accordingly, 'the frequent rotation of officers, the allocation of positions based on tribal affiliation and loyalty, and the punishment of independent thinking all created an armed force lacking in leadership, morale, cohesion and effectiveness' (Gaub 2013). Although the police were in a better situation, they were understaffed and under-equipped, and as a consequence neither the armed forces nor the police were able to offer a base for the foundation of the new Libyan security apparatus. The second problem related to the Political Isolation Law (PIL). In May 2013 Libya's General National Congress (GNC) passed the PIL, which 'bars any officer who commanded a unit under the previous regime from being employed in the military' (Gaub 2013). The PIL resembled the infamous Order 2 'Dissolution of entities' that Paul Bremer, then director of the Coalition Provisional Authority, issued in May 2003 in Iraq, ushering in so-called 'de-Ba'athification'. As in Iraq, such a measure helped to fuel internal conflict instead of redirecting it towards a path of pacification.

To further complicate the Libyan picture, after years of political turmoil, Libya has two governments and several militias. The Government of National Accord (GNA), formed under the terms of the Libyan Political Agreement signed on 17 December 2015 and led by Fayez al-Sarraj, is the only

government that is internationally recognised. The GNC is based in Tripoli and led by Kalifa al-Gawil, who contests the authority of the GNA and attempted two coups in October and December 2016. Moreover, General Haftar has led the Libyan National Army (LNA) in the east since May 2014, controls vast areas of Libya and some of its oil fields, and has probably the best-equipped army in Libya. His coalition 'brought together elements of the Libyan army, including its special forces unit in Benghazi, tribal elements, and nationalists' (Joffé 2016, 12). By contrast, Misrata militias support the GNA and they fought against ISIS in Sirte.

George Joffé accurately describes the chaotic Libyan situation: 'Libya now confronts a threefold crisis [...] There are now two governments opposed to each other; the crisis in security that lies behind this was a consequence of the collapse of the Libyan army [...]; and the outcome of this has been the growth of extremism and instability that now threatens to affect the North African region and has drawn in neighbouring states to support their preferred clients' (Joffé 2016, 1).

According to Joffé, the involvement of external actors in Libya is a result of the way in which the NATO intervention in 2011 took place. The resistance to Gaddafi 'was articulated by a series of spontaneously formed militias. Thus, individual states necessarily engaged with and became patrons of different entities among these militias' (Joffé 2016, 5; Mezran and Varvelli 2017). Therefore, the Libyan situation has been very volatile and complex. Moreover, Libya has suffered from at least three interlinked crises: the crisis over domestic security; the crisis over governance; and the problem of the rampant criminality that affects both.

This political havoc and instability paved the way for ISIS in 2014. Two elements should be noted. First, while in Iraq, ISIS emerged as the result of a political vacuum that followed the American operation *Iraqi Freedom* and as a group was present since the beginning of the Iraqi insurgency in 2003, albeit under a different name. In Libya it was a latecomer. It did not take part in the revolution against Gaddafi or in the conflicts that followed. As a consequence – and this is the second element – instead of having been a protagonist of Libya's conflict from the very beginning, ISIS was just one of several jihadist groups, and the most recent one. Moreover, at the beginning, ISIS's ability to expand in Libya was not related to its military abilities to conquer and defend terrain. Instead, it was related more to its ability to recruit members from local tribes and from other Islamic militias, such as Ansar al-Sharia, which was allegedly responsible for the attack on the US government facility in Benghazi and for killing the US Ambassador Christopher J. Stevens. More often than not, these new recruits decided to pledge their loyalty to ISIS leader Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi in exchange for funds and media coverage that ISIS at that time could offer. Then ISIS sent into Libya its foreign fighters with war experience gained in Iraq and Syria. In Libya, ISIS mainly infiltrated two

areas: Derna and Sirte (Varvelli 2016). However, ISIS has also operated in Benghazi, Ajdabiyah, Tripoli, Misrata, and Sabratha and in the more remote southern regions (Chivvis 2016).

Not coincidentally, the first ISIS foothold in Libya was in the city of Derna in Cyrenaica. This region has a long history of jihadism (Brahimi 2012). In fact, according to data, Libyans form a huge proportion of foreign fighters for different Islamic militias (Fishman and Felter 2007). Moreover, Libyan and Saudi Arabian foreign fighters have previously represented the majority of suicide attackers in Iraq: 'Libyan jihadists form the largest group per capita of foreign fighters supporting Al-Qaeda and the other militias in Iraq and, most recently, Syria' (Varvelli 2016). Furthermore, according to Fishman and Felter, 84% of the total number of Libyan foreign fighters come from Cyrenaica (60% from Derna; 24% from Bengasi [Benghazi]) (Fishman and Felter 2007). Therefore, the area has been prone to radicalisation, and in April 2014 a group of these Libyan foreign fighters, named the Bataar Brigade, returned to Derna, joining the Islamic Youth Shura Council. In October 2014 they pledged allegiance to al-Baghdadi who, after accepting the group, created the first ISIS province in Libya (Wilayat Barqa), which was also the first ISIS province outside Iraq and Syria, and sent three of its officials there, including Abu Nabil al-Anbari (Chivvis 2016), who became the first ISIS leader in Libya and was then killed by a US airstrike in eastern Libya in November 2015. According to Varvelli, the group in Derna was composed of 300 jihadists who had previously fought in Deir el-Zor in Syria and in Mosul in Iraq. By the end of November, the group numbered 800 members and had six training camps on Derna's outskirts (Varvelli 2016). It should be noted that the first ISIS Brigade, al-Battar Brigade, was composed entirely of Libyan volunteers, who began returning from the war in Syria and Iraq. Only after establishing itself in Libya, ISIS began to send their foreign fighters in order to mount major operations. It is impossible to know their exact number, but reliable sources estimate the overall presence of militants in Libya as around 5,000–6,000. As a consequence, Derna rapidly became a key ISIS foothold and the most important one in terms of recruitment in the whole of North Africa. However, the group was not able to control the city for long due to the fact that ISIS was not the only militia and did not have a firm grip over the local population (Beccaro 2018b). The revolt against ISIS erupted in June 2015 after the killing of Nasir al-Akar, who was connected to Al-Qaeda and was a member of the Mujaheddin Shura Council, a militia that has operated since the revolt of 2011. Eventually, ISIS was expelled from Derna in July 2015, even though some ISIS pockets remain in the eastern suburbs of the city.

The situation in Sirte was partially different: first, because ISIS arrived there later than in Derna; second, because in Sirte it was able to conquer not only the city but also a vast area along the coastline; third, while more than half Libyan foreign fighters originated from the city of Derna, just 6% comes

from Sirte. Moreover, in Sirte ISIS may have been facilitated to a certain extent by a local situation similar to that in Iraq, where it has used the support of former Baathists and former regime members to become rooted in local politics. Sirte was the hometown of Gaddafi and of his tribe, Qaddafa, which after the fall of the regime was marginalised. Consequently, some of its members saw in ISIS a new opportunity to regain power, at least in the Sirte area. ISIS in Sirte came from a branch of Ansar al-Sharia, took advantage of the weakness of local militias, was able to give support and to be supported by some former regime's members and then has been able to funnel foreign fighters from Middle East war theatres to Libya. However, it is difficult to know in which proportion these different factors were at play.

One of ISIS's tools was the use of terror and targeted killing in order to eliminate possible competitors and to subjugate the local population. In Sirte it followed this path in August 2015, killing a popular Salafi cleric, Khalid bin Rajab al-Firjani, who after criticising ISIS refused to give permission for his mosque to be used for sermons. The killing prompted an armed uprising that ISIS suppressed using armoured vehicles and heavy weapons, and by executing members of the Firjan tribe. Then ISIS's members went to Tripoli, where, with the support of Tripoli-based Salafi commanders, it started a military training camp and formed the 604th Infantry Battalion. In May 2016 it joined the Misrata militias in the battle to liberate Sirte from ISIS (Wehrey 2016). The story of the Firjan tribe is interesting because their members are not Salafi, like ISIS, but quietist. This underscores the complexity of the Libyan battlefield, where different geopolitical interests, tribes, economic goals, and religious movements are at odds.

As previously stated, in Sirte ISIS benefited at least partially from former Gaddafi regime members. For example, Hassan al Karrami, one of the Libyan leaders of ISIS in Sirte, had family ties with the clan of Ismail Karrami, who was head of the anti-drug agency during the Gaddafi regime (Varvelli 2016, 101). However, links such as these are tenuous and people like Karrami are only sporadically involved in Libya, especially compared to the strong involvement in ISIS of former Baathist members in Iraq (Beccaro 2018b). Moreover, as the fighting with the Firjan tribe demonstrated, the alliance between ISIS and Libya's tribes appears very fragile.

ISIS established its foothold in Sirte in January 2015. It was able to set up a weak presence at the Ouagadougou Conference Center in Sirte due to the tribal links of Ansar al-Sharia in Libya (ASL) and former Gaddafi officials. Moreover, ASL became a means for ISIS to gain information on possible new recruits in their community. According to Zelin, on 14 February 2015, 42 individuals from the Ministry of Interior pledged alliance to ISIS and paid a fee. Then ISIS took neighbourhoods and districts outside Sirte on 8 February, and targeted the radio station, the Wataniya television studio, the immigration centre, Ibn Sina Hospital, the University of Sirte, and local government

buildings. By the end of February 2015, ISIS controlled more than half the city. In late May 2015, ISIS seized al-Qardabiya Air Base and the Great Man-Made River irrigation complex; on 9 June, it took Sirte's power plant, thus controlling the city. ISIS coupled these military operations with activities aimed at speeding its message to the local population (*dawa* activities) and enforcing the correct sharia regulations (*hisba* activities). As a result of the latter, ISIS destroyed the Sufi shrines inciting the fight with the al-Firjan tribe.

Having control of the city, ISIS started a more violent campaign to track down so-called apostates – that is, those who opposed ISIS or did not want to pledge. In early August, ISIS killed Salem Mohammed al-Namli, a member of the Khoms Court of Appeal, and then Khalid bin Rajab al-Firjani. The latter killing unsurprisingly provoked an uprising, one which ISIS managed to suppress, killing some 200 people (Zelin 2016a).

Although ISIS in Sirte had no tanks, armoured personnel carriers (APCs), or similar military vehicles, as it did in Syria and Iraq, and acquired weapons from other militias (Chivvis 2016), it planned to expand its control in villages around Sirte, including al-Wushka and Wadi Zamzam to the west and Bin Jawad to the east. Moreover, ISIS tested both Misrata militias by penetrating checkpoints and security infrastructure and oil facility security. To govern the city, ISIS activated its police and sharia courts, carried out executions, imposed physical penalties, and strictly controlled media and the Internet. However, it failed to present itself as a ruler.

The ISIS presence in Libya worried the international community. Consequently, the GNA was pressured to take action against ISIS in Sirte. Backed by the United States, it launched an offensive on 12 May 2016 east of Assdada. Soon afterwards, GNA military forces recaptured Abu Grein and the al-Wushkah district. As it did in Iraq, ISIS tried to divert security forces using its preferred tactics, i.e. suicide attacks. On 19 May, an ISIS suicide bomber attacked GNA forces, 90 kilometres west of Sirte, killing 30 soldiers and wounding 50. On 12 June, GNA forces secured both Sirte's port and airport, while ISIS fighters retreated into a densely built-up area, with snipers taking up positions, and also started using suicide bombers. Between 2015 and 2016, ISIS used suicide bombers in Libya at least 16 times, killing around 170 people (UCSAD). The fighting continued for weeks. The advance into Sirte's urban area was steady but very slow as a result of ISIS tactics such as suicide attacks, car bombs, and snipers. For this reason, on 1 August 2016 the United States started to support the GNA with their air-power; Marine Corps 'Harriers' were launched from the *USS Wasp* off the coast of Sirte. Between August and December 'US forces launched 495 precision airstrikes in an around Sirte [...] The bombings targeted Vehicle Borne Improvised Explosive Devices, heavy guns, tanks, command and control centers and fighting positions' (Joscelyn 2017). The airstrikes were conducted at GNA's request and they represented 'an additional U.S. step beyond the

previously acknowledged provision of intelligence and tactical advice' (Fishman 2016). Moreover, they served as strong, albeit not decisive, support to Prime Minister Fayez al-Sarraj and 'emphasized that the airstrikes came at the GNA's request, will be time-limited, and will not extend beyond the Sirte area' (Fishman 2016). It should be noted that the airstrikes were just the more visible part of US and Western involvement in Libya, because since the end of 2015, 'American Special Operations troops have been stationed at two outposts in eastern and western Libya [...] tasked with lining up local partners [...] Two teams totalling fewer than 25 troops are operating from around the cities of Misurata and Benghazi to identify potential allies among local armed factions and gather intelligence on threats' (Ryan 2016). Far from being the only Western units on the ground, the US Special Operations Forces (SOF) represented just one of the international contingents, which included French, British, and allegedly Italian representation.

On 10 August, after weeks of fierce fighting, the GNA seized the Ouagadougou Center where ISIS held religious meetings, the hospital, and the university campus. After a stalemate in September, Libyan forces were able to isolate the last ISIS-controlled areas in October. On 22 October, pro-GNA militias captured the '600' neighbourhood, leaving only the Jizah area under ISIS control, and only on 7 December could the GNA announce it had completely liberated Sirte.

However, Libya and Sirte were not the only ISIS theatres of operations at the time. In fact, over the same period, 2014–2016, it operated in neighbouring countries, as the operation in Ben Gardane, Tunisia, in March 2016 demonstrates.

ISIS in North Africa, 2014–2016

The previous section showed how ISIS campaigned in Libya. The following part of this paper moves on to describe ISIS's links and operations in North Africa. Although a full and in-depth discussion is outside the scope of this study, the section below intends to offer an overview of ISIS operations in the region and the security threats that the countries have had to confront. The aim is to highlight the main security problems both at political/strategic level, mentioning the major threats to those countries, and at tactical level with a chronicle of the major terrorist attacks. It is important to bear in mind that although Islamist militias are not new in the region, ISIS is a recent actor. North Africa has a relatively long history related to contemporary jihadism. For instance, several Libyans fought in Afghanistan against the Soviets and then in the 1990s they founded the Libyan Islamic Fighting Group (LIFG). However, the turning point in the evolution of Islamic groups was the civil war in Algeria, 'which became the cradle of an enduring version of jihadism that expanded through the Sahara' (Filiu 2015). According

to Brian Fishman, as far as instability, security, and jihadism are concerned, one of the problems in the region is that '[g]overnments have tended to focus their attention on the coastal cities, ignoring the interior regions' (Fishman 2015). As a result, smuggling, human trafficking, and ungoverned spaces are rampant and are exploited by militias so as to support their operations (Joffé 2017).

Although not every militia that operates in the North Africa region is linked to ISIS and it has pledged allegiance to al-Baghdadi, ISIS has been able to take advantage of local militias to expand, like in Libya. Despite the fact that ISIS is in retreat in every war theatre and its online propaganda has dropped significantly in the last two years (Milton 2016), in the past it showed that it can simply go underground, relying more on terrorist methods of fighting in order to re-emerge later. Moreover, in North Africa ISIS has some linked militias that it could use to enhance its regional influence (Warner 2017).

Although 1,500 Moroccans are believed to have joined ISIS, the country has witnessed only minor incidents related to ISIS (Joffé 2017). For this reason, this paper focuses on Algeria, Tunisia, and Egypt.

Algeria

The security situation in Algeria is relatively calm when compared to Libya. Bombings and attacks have been rare in Algeria since it ended its decade-long civil war. Nevertheless, Algeria has had a series of problems related to jihadist militias (Barka 2012). Al-Qaeda in the Islamic Maghreb (AQIM) is still active. In 2014, militants broke away from AQIM and organised in eastern Algeria the Jund al-Khalifah, which became an ISIS affiliate. It notoriously beheaded a French tourist and has attacked policemen. ISIS itself launched several attacks in October 2016 in Skikda province.

Long borders with Libya, Tunisia, and Mali pose security problems for Algeria (e.g. ISIS attacked Algerian soldiers along the Malian border in 2020). Algeria has also been worried about the fact that Tunisians have fought for ISIS in Iraq, Syria, and Libya. Data on the number of foreign fighters must be interpreted with caution; however, according to Schmid, Tunisia is one of the main contributors of foreign fighters to ISIS, with roughly 3000 fighters, whereas Algeria, despite its larger population, has contributed only 170 (Schmid 2015). The same source also quotes data from the ISIS database, based on which the situation appears even more serious because it states that 21% of ISIS foreign fighters come from Libya and 16% from Tunisia, while Algeria is not cited. Their return represented a major threat for the region. This is evident taking into account two events that happened soon after the fall of Sirte. On 6 January 2017 Algeria announced a state of emergency on its border with Tunisia due to the fear that 800 Tunisian foreign fighters might enter Algeria (MEMO 2017). Fearing infiltration by

ISIS and Islamist militants through Libya and Mali, on 29 January 2017 the Algerian Army and Air Force were put on high alert. It should also be noted that most of Algeria's land frontier has been under military control since 2014 when Algerian president Abdelaziz Bouteflika transferred border control operations from the ministry of the interior to the army. Moreover, there had been 'increased sorties from jet fighters and helicopters scanning the sky over the border' (Ghanmi 2017).

Despite the limited numbers of attacks, Algeria is in a very volatile situation because of at least three factors (Joffé 2017): the instability of its neighbouring countries; the 2015 collapse in oil price, which has created a very worrying economic environment; and the resulting internal instability, after which, on 2 April 2019, President Abdelaziz Bouteflika resigned, following pressure from mass protests against a fifth term.

Tunisia

The situation in Tunisia is different and more volatile for at least four reasons: Tunisian security forces are ill-equipped; the local economic situation is stagnant (Joffé 2017); Tunisia's borders with both Algeria and Libya have become insecure; and Tunisia has a serious problem with foreign fighters. It should be noted that Tunisian jihadists (Pargeter 2012) have deep and strong links to ISIS that date back to the founder of ISIS, al-Zarqawi. Some Tunisians joined his small group, based in Kurdistan, at the time, even before the American invasion of Iraq (Zelin 2016b). The foreign fighters' situation in Tunisia is grave, not only because the number of combatants who can return from Libya or Syria/Iraq is very high, especially compared to the size of the Tunisian population, but also because it can provoke social protest. In fact, on 9 January 2017 at least 1,000 people protested in central Tunis against allowing Tunisian foreign fighters back into the country.

On 18 March 2015, three Islamic militants attacked the Bardo National Museum in Tunis. Twenty-two people, mostly European tourists, were killed. However, the first known ISIS operation took place on 8 April 2015 near the town of Sbeitla, where militants ambushed a military convoy, killing four soldiers. On April 22, ISIS claimed responsibility for an attack in Jabal Salloum, southeast of Kasserine city. During this attack an Algerian ISIS militant was killed. On 26 June 2015, a mass shooting occurred at a tourist resort near the city of Sousse when a gunman linked to ISIS, Seifeddine Rezgui, attacked the beach at the resort and the associated hotel. Thirty-eight people, mostly British, were killed, and it was the deadliest attack in the history of modern Tunisia (Günay and Sommariva 2019). Although investigators found out that Rezgui had links to the Islamic State, he was not a member of a cell or group. Due to such 'lone wolf' tactics, and even though it has not organised cells in every country, ISIS is able to threaten regional stability. According to

Zelin, both these large-scale attacks had links to ISIS in Libya (Zelin 2016b). On 24 November 2015, 12 Tunisian Presidential Security guards were killed in a bus bombing in Tunis. The bomber was identified as Houssein Abdelli, a 28-year-old resident of Tunis, and ISIS claimed responsibility. With regard to borders, on February 2016, Tunisia completed the construction of a barrier consisting of berms and water-filled trenches along its border with Libya. The Libyan border is a constant threat for Tunisia, as the frequent skirmishes between security forces and militants show. For instance, on 3 March 2016 five militants were killed by Tunisian forces near the Libyan border and explosive vests and improvised grenades were recovered.

In March 2016, ISIS tried to take over the border city of Ben Gardane, which was notorious because it was a hotbed of foreign fighters. As in Iraq and in Sirte, ISIS tried to co-opt local tribes before launching an assault on the city on 7 March. It involved sleeper cells and other units that crossed the border from Libya and began an assault on the gendarmerie and army barracks, killing 30 security officials. However, the assault failed because the local population resisted ISIS and security forces were able to counter-attack. The Ben Gardane assault illustrated the hybrid nature of ISIS because it demonstrated not only ISIS's ability to conduct large-scale and cross-border operations (Chivvis 2016), but also its strategic goal of conquering a key city and of controlling terrain. On 19 May, security forces killed a local ISIS leader, Seifeddine Jameli, known as Abou al-Qaaqaa, in the Mount Mghilla region and, according to the Tunisian Interior Minister, security forces 'dismantled 160 jihadist cells in the first 10 months of this year, about 45 percent more than during the whole of 2015' (Reuters 2016).

Tunisia remains a key Western ally in the region to fight radical militias and ISIS, in particular. The military collaboration between Tunisia and the United States is very close and was very useful for the American support of Misrata militias during the battle for Sirte. In fact, on 26 October 2016 the US government admitted that some of its drones had been flying out of Tunisia since late June.

Egypt

The situation of Egypt, in the light of the Libyan conflict, is rather complex due to its political and military involvement. Both Algeria and Tunisia have to deal with Libyan instability; however, neither of them has been directly involved in the conflict. In contrast, Egypt is politically and militarily involved given its support for Haftar. Furthermore, Egyptian interests in Libya, mainly in Cyrenaica, place Egypt in a difficult position, completely different from that of Tunisia and Algeria. This is shown by at least two factors. To begin with, in July 2014 the first attack in the Western Desert appeared to have been carried out by 'an expeditionary force that struck the Farafra checkpoint

before moving up to Marsa Matruh, then back east on the way to Sinai' (Awad 2016). Moreover, Egyptian intelligence has identified a network of boats connecting the Sinai and Libyan coasts. Therefore, the problem of ISIS has to be taken into account in the light of this more complex relationship and of the political instability of Egypt itself following the Arab Spring and the increase in terrorist attacks in the country.

For instance, on 7 January 2016 gunmen opened fire on an Israeli tour bus in Cairo without injuring anyone, while at Bella Vista hotel, in the Red Sea area, an attack by a knife-wielding assailant wounded several people. Cairo has often been targeted; on 23 January six police officers and three civilians were killed when the police raided a home rigged with explosives; the ISIS claimed credit for the attack. On 8 May gunmen killed eight plain-clothes police officers in a drive-by shooting in an industrial neighbourhood in Cairo. ISIS claimed culpability for the attack, as well as for the bomb at the Italian consulate in Cairo on 11 July. On 11 December a bomb killed 25 people inside a Cairo Coptic church. At the beginning of January 2017 assailants on a motorcycle fatally shot an Egyptian policeman in Cairo. The Islamic State is not the only security threat in Egypt, yet it is a serious one responsible for seven attacks in Cairo in 2016 and for four in 2015.

Most of the ISIS-related violence has taken place in the Sinai Peninsula. Originally known as Ansar Beit al-Maqdis, the group changed its name to Wilayat Sinai, and pledged allegiance to ISIS, in November 2014. From that date onwards, it has been the most active insurgent group in Egypt and the most active ISIS affiliate outside Libya. It has carried out dozens of attacks that have killed hundreds of soldiers and police officers. The group has launched suicide attacks and gun battles mainly in the northern part of the Sinai with the support of local tribes. The ISIS operations in Sinai 'help it spread into the Egyptian mainland and Western Desert, the latter with help also from its Libya base' (Awad 2016).

Sinai has witnessed different kinds of attack (Dentice 2018) that range from skirmishes to mortar attacks to IEDs and car bombs, underlining the similarity in ISIS tactics regardless of the theatre of operations. In fact, ISIS in Sinai 'has methodically focused on demoralization and infiltration through tactics strongly reminiscent of those used by core ISIS in Iraq in preparation for the 2014 conquest' (Awad 2016) of Mosul. On at least two different occasions ISIS was able to kill high-ranking officials. For instance, on 28 January 2016 a bombing in North Sinai's provincial capital of El-Arish killed a colonel and three soldiers. On 14 October 2016, Islamist militants killed 12 soldiers in an attack at an army checkpoint near the town of Bir al-Abd. On 4 November 2016 Brigadier-General Hesham Mahmoud Abualazm, an Egyptian general, was killed by ISIS gunmen near his home in North Sinai. Moreover, in Sinai ISIS has made extensive use of one of its preferred tactics, i.e. suicide car bombs—on 24 November, killing eight soldiers, and on 9 January 2017,

when a truck bomb driven by a suicide attacker in the city of El-Arish killed eight policemen. On 31 January the Islamic State claimed the killing of 20 Egyptian soldiers over four days of clashes in northern Sinai. On 9 February 2017, it claimed credit for firing multiple rockets at Israel's port town of Eilat from the Sinai Peninsula. Although the attack did not cause any casualties it elucidated the seriousness of the situation, also because it used more complex weapons than car bombs. On 16 July 2015 Islamic-State-affiliated militants carried out a missile attack on an Egyptian naval vessel in the Mediterranean Sea. These last two examples point very clearly to the hybrid nature of ISIS, which was able to use advanced weapons such as missiles to strike enemy assets in a 'conventional' way and at the same time carry out terrorist operations such as those aforementioned and the incident of the Russian Metrojet on 31 October 2015 (Gold 2015).

From 2016, Egyptian security forces increased their operations in Sinai in order to end this insurgency and they have killed several militants and destroyed numerous bunkers and hideouts; on 4 August 2016 they also killed Abu Doaa al-Ansari, the local ISIS leader, yet the Sinai situation remains volatile.

Conclusion

ISIS has proved to be resilient and also quite adaptive. Although the loss of its North African capital has been a strategic blow, this has not removed ISIS's ability to execute small-unit raids, and bombings. Over 2015 and 2016, ISIS demonstrated at least three elements that need to be taken into account to gain a clearer idea of modern security threats. First, its penetration in Libya and then its ability to pervade and strike neighbouring countries highlight its cross-border operational ability, but also the reduced relevance of traditional state borders in understanding twenty-first-century security in the light of modern militias. Second, it has shown its willingness – and, on some occasions, as in Sirte, its ability – to conquer terrain and to defend it. It tried to conquer Derna in Libya, then Ben Gardane in Tunisia, and it controls at least part of Sinai. This is a classic feature of a militia, and in term of security this has two consequences. On the one hand, it means that counter-insurgency operations are more likely to be useful against ISIS and similar groups than those related more closely to counterterrorism. On the other hand, control of terrain is crucial in order to eradicate this kind of threat. However, in Libya this kind of control of terrain was lacking and still is lacking. Third, ISIS has demonstrated a remarkable yet worrisome ability to employ different tactics, giving credit to the idea of a hybrid militia. ISIS used classic terrorist operations in Libya, Tunisia, Algeria, and Egypt when it did not have control of terrain or wanted to strike outside the main theatre of operations. At the same time, it has been able to coordinate more

traditional infantry operations, like the operation to conquer Sirte or to attack Ben Gardane. And it has also been able to use modern weapons, as the aforementioned attacks in Sinai have demonstrated. Given its hybridity, adaptability, and its resilience, ISIS remains a particular security threat to North Africa.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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